Rebuilding the House

Ezra 1–6 · Haggai 1–2 · Nehemiah 1–8

The big idea: God kept his promise and brought the exiles home. They rebuilt the altar, the temple, and the walls, not by might but by God's Spirit. Then Ezra read God's word to the people, and they wept and were told, "the joy of the LORD is your strength."

Before you meet: Read

Ezra 1:1–4 | Ezra 3:10–13 | Nehemiah 4:6–23 | Nehemiah 8:1–12

Open (5 minutes)

When have you come home after a long time away? What had changed, and what had stayed the same?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my _____, says the LORD of hosts." *(Zechariah 4:6)*

"For Ezra had set his heart to _____ the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel." *(Ezra 7:10)*

"Each labored on the work with one hand and held his _____ with the other." *(Nehemiah 4:17)*

"Do not be grieved, for the _____ of the LORD is your strength." *(Nehemiah 8:10)*

Discuss

1. At the temple's foundation the old men wept and others shouted for joy. Why did both reactions make sense? *Ezra 3:11–13; Haggai 2:3*

2. Haggai said, Consider your ways. What would change if you put God's priorities ahead of your own projects? *Haggai 1:3–9*

3. Nehemiah's people prayed and also set a guard. How do prayer and practical action work together in your life? *Nehemiah 4:9, 14, 17*

4. When Ezra read God's word, the people wept, and then were told to rejoice. Why do we need both? *Nehemiah 8:8–12*

Memory verse

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

Zechariah 4:6

Pray

Thank God that he keeps his promises. Ask him to rebuild what is broken in your life by his Spirit, and to make his word your joy.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 35

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Ezra 3:10–13 and Nehemiah 8:1–12 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Malachi 3–4 and Luke 2:25–32).

Main points to land

1. God kept his promise to bring the exiles home, even naming Cyrus in advance (Ezra 1:1; Isaiah 44:28).
2. The returned exiles rebuilt the temple by God's Spirit, not by might, and Haggai promised its latter glory would be greater (Zechariah 4:6; Haggai 2:9).
3. Nehemiah rebuilt the walls, and Ezra restored God's word to the center of the people's life (Ezra 7:10; Nehemiah 8:8–10).

Answer key (Observe)

1. Spirit
2. study
3. weapon
4. joy

Questions people will ask

Where does the book of Esther fit, and why is God never named in it?
Esther comes from this period, among Jews who stayed in Persia. God is never named, yet the book shows his quiet providence: a Jewish queen placed in the palace "for such a time as this" (Esther 4:14). Like the "happened" in Ruth 2:3, it teaches that God is at work even when he seems hidden.

Closing prayer

Father, you brought your people home and gave them your word. Rebuild what is broken in us, not by might nor by power but by your Spirit. Thank you for Jesus, the cornerstone of your house. Make your word our joy. Amen.